Revision Notes for Class 11 English

Chapter 1 – The Portrait of a Lady

About the Author and the Key Highlights:

Khushwant Singh, born on February 2, 1915, in Hadali (now Pakistan), was a well-known Indian author, lawyer, diplomat, journalist, and politician. His long career was characterised by his witty and bold writing style, showcasing his deep understanding of Indian society. One of his famous works includes "Train to Pakistan," a touching novel about the Partition of India. For his literary contributions, he received several top awards, such as the Padma Bhushan and Padma Vibhushan.

In "The Portrait of a Lady," Singh describes his grandmother as a calm and timeless woman with silver hair, symbolising wisdom, patience, and strength. The story follows the changes in their relationship from his childhood closeness to the distances created by time and education.

Synopsis of the Story:

"The Portrait of a Lady" by Khushwant Singh is a touching story about the author's relationship with his grandmother. The narrative starts with the author's childhood when he was very close to his grandmother, who played a significant role in his upbringing. As he grows older and moves away for education, their bond changes. The grandmother, portrayed as a calm, wise, and patient woman, continues her routine of praying and feeding birds despite the changes around her. The story highlights themes of family, change, and nostalgia, capturing their evolving relationship and offering insight into the cultural setting of pre-Independent India.

The Theme of Chapter 1 The Portrait Of A Lady

The theme of Chapter 1, "The Portrait of a Lady," in CBSE Class 11 English revolves around the bond between the author and his grandmother. It explores the deep connection they share during his childhood and how it evolves as he grows up and moves away for education. The story highlights the themes of family, change, and nostalgia, showing how relationships transform over time while certain bonds remain strong. It also highlights the grandmother's consistent habits and routines despite these changes, providing a glimpse into the cultural and societal norms of pre-Independent India.

Character Sketches:

In Chapter 1 of "The Portrait of a Lady" by Khushwant Singh, the focus is on the grandmother and how her relationship with the author changes over time. The grandmother is shown as a calm, wise, and patient woman who is very religious and follows her daily routines of praying and feeding birds. Her timeless appearance, with silver hair and white clothes, symbolises her inner peace and strength. The author's character sketch shows his growth from a dependent child to an independent adult, highlighting the changes in their relationship. The chapter emphasises themes of family bonds, change, and the passage of time.

The Portrait Of A Lady Class 11 Summary

1. The Grandmother's Character:

The story describes the grandmother as a peaceful and wise woman with silver hair who always wears white clothes. She spends her days praying and feeding animals, showing her deep religious faith. Her calm and strong character makes her a central figure in the author's life and memories.

2. Evolution of Relationship:

The story shows how the author's relationship with his grandmother changes from childhood to adulthood. They were very close when he was a child, but their bond changes as he grows up and goes away to study. The story highlights how relationships naturally evolve.

3. Themes of Family and Change:

The chapter explores the themes of family bonds, the changes that come with time, and the nostalgia of remembering loved ones. It shows how relationships change but certain bonds stay strong despite physical and emotional distance.

4. Emotional Depth:

The story is full of emotional moments that bring out feelings of longing and love. The grandmother's consistent routine, quiet support, and acceptance of being alone are beautifully depicted. This portrayal connects with readers, reminding them of their family ties and how time changes relationships.

5. Cultural Context:

The story also provides insight into the cultural and societal norms of pre-Independent India, especially the roles and perceptions of elderly women in traditional households.